

Word Of Faith

prc-word-of-faith
Spiritual Gifts · Word of Faith · doctrine · outside_majority_lineages

AFFIRMS

breadth canon-wide
directness direct
variants stable

Statement under examination

Human speech does not possess intrinsic creative force such that "decreeing and declaring" causes God to bring about the speaker's stated outcome; the Creator's word and the creature's word are categorically distinct.

In plain language

The question asks whether a human can speak words that carry their own creative power, so that decreeing and declaring forces God to produce the stated result, and whether a person's word is the same kind of thing as God's word. The Bible's own wording answers this carefully. In Isaiah 55, the word that goes out and never returns 'empty' (reqam), and that accomplishes its purpose, is repeatedly marked as God's word: 'my word' (devari) that goes out 'from my mouth' (mippi), says the Lord. The same chapter says God's 'thoughts' (machashavah) and 'ways' (derek) are as high above ours as the heavens are above the earth, using the verb 'are higher' (gavhu). Genesis 1 uses the Hebrew verb 'to create' (bara), only with God as subject, never with a human. Hebrews 11:3 says the worlds were framed 'by the word of God' (rhemati theou), with the word grammatically attached to God. Psalm 115 says God in heaven does 'all that he pleased' (kol asher chaphets), placing outcome-power in God's will. In James 4, people who confidently say we will go and do business and make a profit are corrected. The right way to speak is, 'if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese), we will live and do this. The other side raises a real cluster of asking-promises: Mark 11:23-24 about telling a mountain to move while believing (pisteuo), Matthew 7:7-8 'ask and it will be given' (aiteite kai dothesetai), John 14:13-14 whatever you ask 'in my name' (en to onomati mou) I will do, John 15:7 ask whatever you wish. These are strong promises. But the same letter cluster supplies the limit. 1 John 5:14 says, if we ask anything 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou), he hears us. John 15:7 ties asking to remaining (meino) in Christ and to Christ's 'words' (rhemata) remaining in the speaker. The canon then supplies the suffering data: Paul's 'thorn' (skolops) in 2 Corinthians 12, a word that occurs only once in the whole New Testament, was asked away three times and denied. Timothy's stomach trouble, Epaphroditus' illness, Trophimus left sick, all stand inside the period when the asking-promises were in force. So the words do say ask and receive, but they grammatically place God as the giver and divine will as the scope. The human word can bless, pray, plan, and trust, but it does not carry the Creator's power to call things into being or to compel God. The lexical pattern across both Testaments supports the proposition.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1254	בָּרָא	bara	to create	54
H1361	גָּבַהּ	gabah	to exult	33
H1697	דָּבָר	dabar	word	1,442
H1870	דֶּרֶךְ	derekh	way	
H2654	חָפֵץ	chaphets	to delight in	75

H3808	לֹא	lo	not	
H4284	מַחַשְׁבָּה	machashabah	plot	52
H6213	עָשָׂה	asah	to make	2,629
H6310	פֶּה	peh	lip	498
H7387	רֶקֶם	reqam	emptily	16
H8064	שָׁמַיִם	shamayim	heaven	
G0154	αἰτέω	aiteo	to ask	70
G0225	ἀλήθεια	alētheia	truth	
G0444	ἄνθρωπος	anthropos	a human	567
G1252	διακρίνω	diakrinō	to judge/doubt	
G1325	δίδωμι	didōmi	to give	
G1437	εἰάν	ean	if	374
G1710	ἐμπορεύομαι	emporeuomai	to traffic in	
G2150	εὐσέβεια	eusebeia	piety	15
G2198	ζάω	zaō	to live	
G2307	θέλημα	thelema	will/desire	63
G2309	θέλω	thelo	to will/desire	211
G2596	κατά	kata	according to	477
G2675	καταρτίζω	katartizō	to complete	
G2770	κερδαίνω	kerdainō	to gain	
G2983	λαμβάνω	lambano	to take	264
G3735	ὄρος	oros	mountain	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	243
G4200	πορισμός	porismos	gain	2
G4487	ῥῆμα	rhema	declaration	71
G4647	σκόλοψ	skolops	thorn	1

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The anchor cluster lexically locates outcome-producing speech in the divine first person. Isaiah 55:11 reads 'my word' (devari), going out 'from my mouth' (mippi), and not returning 'empty' (reqam), but accomplishing what the LORD 'delights or wills' (chaphets). The same passage raises 'the heavens' (shamayim) above the earth ('are higher', gavhu, H1361) to mark divine 'way' (derek) and 'thought' (machashavah) as categorically above the human (Isaiah 55:8-9). Psalm 115:3 grounds outcome in 'God' (elohim) doing 'all that he pleased' (kol asher chaphets), never in a human declaration. The asking-promise texts that the positive-confession reading cites (Mark 11:23-24, Matthew 7:7-8, John 14:13-14, John 15:7, James 1:5-6) are addressed to God in the second person and resolved by the 'according to his will' (kata to thelema) condition in 1 John 5:14, 'if we ask anything according to his will' (ean ti aitometha kata to thelema autou). James 4:13-15 rebukes confident self-decree with 'if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese). Across canon the lexical pattern places efficacious creative force in the Creator's word and will, not in the creature's spoken decree, supporting the proposition.

Scripture

Isa.55.8 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H4284 מַחֲשֵׁבוֹת, H1870 דֶּרֶךְ; H3808 לֹא

Force. First-person divine speech, 'declares the LORD' (neum YHWH), declares 'my thoughts are not your thoughts' (lo machshevotai machshevotekem). The negation 'not' (lo, H3808) governs the equation of human and divine 'thought' (machashavah) and 'way' (derek), which establishes the qualitative gap the proposition asserts.

Isa.55.9 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1361 גָּבַהּ, H8064 שָׁמַיִם

Force. The verb 'are higher' (gavhu), with 'heavens' (shamayim) above the earth, measures the distance between divine and human 'way' (derek) and 'thought' (machashavah). The vertical comparison is the lexical engine of categorical distinction. The creature's way and thought are not elevated to the Creator's by any utterance.

Isa.55.11 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H1697 דָּבַר, H6310 פֶּה; H7387 רִיקָם, H2654 תָּפַץ

Force. The effective word is 'my word' (devari), marked by first-person suffix and qualified 'from my mouth' (mippi, the LORD's). It does not return 'empty' (reqam, a rare term with only 16 Old Testament occurrences), but accomplishes 'what I willed' (asher chaphatsti), and prospers what He sent it to do. The accomplishing power is bound to divine speech and divine will, never to a human speaker. The text gives no warrant for transferring this self-fulfilling force to the creature's word.

Ps.115.3 · **for** · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6213 עָשָׂה, H2654 תָּפַץ

Force. 'Our God is in the heavens, all that he pleased he did' (Eloheinu vashamayim kol asher chaphets asah). Outcome ('did', asah, H6213) is tied to divine 'pleasure or will' (chaphets), located 'in the heavens' (bashamayim). The locus of efficacious will is God, not a human declaration on earth.

Jas.4.13 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1710 ἐμπορεύομαι, G2770 κερδαίνω

Force. The merchants confidently announce future action and profit, 'today or tomorrow we will go' (semeron e aurion poreusometha), and 'we will make a profit' (kerdesomen), in future indicatives (statements of fact about what will happen). James frames this self-declaring certainty about outcomes as the error to be corrected, not as a model of speech that secures results.

Jas.4.15 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλω, G1437 ἔάν, G2198 ζάω

Force. The corrected speech form is 'if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese), with conditional 'if' (ean, G1437) plus aorist subjunctive (a completed-action verb form used after 'if') of 'to will' (thelo, G2309). Human plans and life itself are subordinated to the Lord's will. Outcome is suspended on divine 'willing' (thelo), not produced by the speaker's assertion, which directly counters any creative force in human decree.

1John.5.14 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0154 αἰτέω, G2596 κατά, G2307 θέλημα

Force. 'If we ask anything according to his will, he hears us' (ean ti aitometha kata to thelema autou akouei hemon). The asking-promise carries an explicit conditional ('if-then' clause), 'if' (ean) plus subjunctive 'we ask' (aitometha), with the qualifier 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou). The construction makes divine will the controlling clause, not the speaker's wish. This single verse integrates the asking-promise texts (Matthew 7:7-8, John 14:13-14, John 15:7, Mark 11:24, James 1:5-6) by giving their lexical scope.

1Tim.6.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2150 εὐσέβεια, G4200 πορισμός, G0225 ἀλήθεια

Force. Paul names a corrupted class, 'having a corrupted mind and bereft of the truth' (diephtharmenon ton noun kai apesteremenon tes aletheias), 'supposing godliness to be a means of gain' (nomizonton porismon einai ten eusebeian). 'Means of gain' (porismos, G4200) is a near-hapax (a word that occurs only once or twice in the entire Bible, only at 1 Timothy 6:5-6), and Paul uses it precisely to label and reject the gain-from-piety equation. The lexical force directly targets any teaching that recasts faith as a technique for procuring material outcomes.

Heb.11.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4487 ῥῆμα, G2675 καταρτίζω

Force. 'The worlds were framed by the word of God' (katertisthai tous aionas rhemati theou). The creative 'word' (rhema) is anchored to 'of God' (theou, a noun in the 'from-X' grammatical form, the genitive), and to the act of 'framing or fitting' (katartizo). The text grammatically restricts world-framing speech to God, never extending it to believers. 'Faith' (pistei) here is the means of cognition, not the engine of creation.

Mark.11.23 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: hyperbole

Key terms. G3735 ὅρος, G4100 πιστεύω, G1252 διακρίνω

Force. 'Whoever may say to this mountain' (hos an eipe to orei touto), with the proviso 'does not waver in his heart but believes' (me diakrithe en te kardia autou alla pisteue). The next verse pairs this with 'when you pray' (proseuchesthe), framing the saying as believing prayer addressed to God. The mountain-saying is a prayer act, with God as the agent who moves the mountain, not an autonomous creative utterance.

2Cor.12.7 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4647 σκόλοψ, G1325 δίδωμι

Force. 'A thorn in the flesh' (skolops te sarki), 'was given to me' (edothē moi, the passive of 'to give', didomi). 'Thorn' (skolops) is a New Testament hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire New Testament). Paul 'asks' (parekalesa) three times for its removal and is denied with 'my grace is sufficient for you' (arkei soi he charis mou). The asking-receiving formula does not produce the asked outcome here, which lexically forecloses any reading of the asking-promises as unconditional guarantees of speaker-stated results.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Ps.115.3	Ps.135.6	tsk	1
Ps.115.3	Ps.2.4	tsk	1
Jas.4.13	Prov.27.1	tsk	1
Isa.55.11	Isa.44.26	tsk	1
Jas.4.15	2Sam.15.25	tsk	1
Isa.55.9	Ps.36.5	tsk	1
1John.5.14	John.14.13	openbible	1
1John.5.14	John.15.7	openbible	1
1John.5.14	Matt.7.7	openbible	1
Mark.11.23	Matt.21.21	tsk	1
Mark.11.24	Jas.1.6	openbible	1
2Cor.12.7	2Cor.12.9	tsk	1
1Tim.6.5	1Tim.6.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Mark.11.24 · addressed

'All things whatever you pray and ask, believe that you have received, and it will be to you' (panta hosa proseuchesthe kai aiteisthe, pisteuete hoti elabete, kai estai hymin). The verbs 'you pray' (proseuchesthe) and 'you ask' (aiteisthe) make the saying an act of petition directed to God, with God as agent. The phrase is integrated by 1 John 5:14, 'if we ask anything according to his will' (ean ti aitometha kata to thelema autou), asking 'according to' (kata) his will, and is qualified by the suffering data where the same asking pattern fails to produce the asked outcome (2 Corinthians 12:7-9). The lexical structure is conditional petition, not autonomous decree.

Matt.7.7 · addressed

'Ask and it will be given to you' (aiteite kai dothesetai hymin), with passive 'it will be given' (dothesetai, G1325 from didomi, 'to give') marking God as the unstated agent. The asking-promise has a divine grantor, not a self-fulfilling word. The same writer (Matthew 26:39) records Jesus' Gethsemane prayer 'nevertheless not as I will but as you will' (plen ouch hos ego thelo all hos sy). The asking-promises operate within the will of the Father, not above it.

John.14.13 · addressed

'Whatever you ask in my name I will do it' (ho ti an aitesete en to onomati mou touto poieso). The agent of 'I will do' (poieso) is the Son, 'so that the Father may be glorified in the Son' (hina doxasthe ho pater en to huio). 'In my name' (en to onomati mou) is not a verbal formula appended to a wish; it locates the asking within the Son's mission and the Father's glory. 1 John 5:14 supplies the explicit scope, 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou).

John.15.7 · addressed

'Whatever you wish ask, and it will be done for you' (ho ean thelete aitesasthe, kai genesetai hymin), is conditioned by the prior clause 'if you remain in me and my words remain in you' (ean meinete en emoi kai ta rhemata mou en hymin meino). The 'remaining' or 'abiding' (meino) and the indwelling 'words' (rhemata, Christ's words, not the speaker's) precondition the asking. The promise is not detachable from the abiding-in-Christ constraint.

Jas.1.6 · addressed

'Let him ask in faith, doubting nothing' (aiteito de en pistei meden diakrinomenos). The wider context is asking God for 'wisdom' (sophia, James 1:5), within God's gift. The same letter (James 4:3) immediately corrects misdirected asking, 'you ask and do not receive because you ask wrongly' (aiteite kai ou lambanete, dioti kakos aiteisthe). Faith is the posture of asking, not a force that compels the answer.

Prov.18.21 · addressed

'Death and life are in the power of the tongue' (mavet vechayim beyad lashon), is a wisdom proverb about the moral and relational consequences of speech (blessing, slander, counsel), as the parallel clause about eating its fruit shows. The genre is proverbial generalization about human conduct, not a metaphysical claim that the tongue possesses intrinsic creative force over external reality. It does not transfer the Creator's efficacious word to the creature.

John.10.34 · addressed

'I said you are gods' (ego eipa theoi este), quoting Psalm 82:6. In the psalm the 'gods' (elohim) addressed are Israel's judges or rulers under indictment, and the next clause (Psalm 82:7) declares 'nevertheless you will die like men' (aken keadam temutun), stripping any ontological deity from them. The lemma 'gods' (elohim) here functions as a title of delegated office under judgment, not a claim that humans share divine being or wield divine creative speech.

Heb.11.3 · addressed

'The worlds were framed by the word of God' (katertisthai tous aionas rhemati theou). The creative 'word' (rhema) is grammatically restricted by the genitive (the 'from-X' form) 'of God' (theou), and the chapter offers Hebrews 11's heroes as those who acted 'by faith' (pistei), never as speakers whose word framed worlds. Faith perceives the divine creative word; it does not replicate it.

Gen.1.3 · addressed

'And God said let there be light and there was light' (vayomer elohim yehi or vayehi or). The subject of 'said' (vayomer) is 'God' (elohim). The creative speech is the Creator's, formally marked by the verb 'to create' (bara', H1254, with 54 Old Testament occurrences) whose grammatical subject is God in every theologically loaded use (Genesis 1:1, 1:21, 1:27). 'To create' (bara') has no recorded human agent. The creation pattern lexically restricts world-calling speech to God.

Concordance traversed

H1697, H2654, H6213, H4284, H1361, H6310, H7387, H8064, H1254, G2309, G2307, G1437, G2596, G0154, G2983, G4100, G4487, G4647, G2150, G4200, G0444

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

James 4:13-15 carries marked variation in the apparatus ('we will travel for trade' (emporeusometha) versus 'we will go' (poreusometha), 'we will do' (poiesomen), 'we will make a profit' (kerdesomen), 'we will live' (zesomen), 'and we will do' (kai poiesomen)), but every reading keeps the same conditional 'if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese) structure. Mark 11:23-24 has minor variation in 'he has' (echei) versus 'you have' (echete) and order of clauses, none disturbing the 'you pray, you ask, you believe' (proseuchesthe-aiteisthe-pisteuete) petition frame. 1 John 5:14, 'if we ask anything' (ean ti aitometha), is textually stable in the manuscripts. Isaiah and Psalm anchors are Old Testament and outside ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) scope. The verdict holds across all plausible variant readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. creator_creature_distinction, word_of_faith_positive_confession, kingdom_now_dominion

[analogia scripturae](#) invoked

creator_creature_distinction: affirms the proposition · Isaiah 55:8-11 lexically separates the divine word from the 'mouth' ('from my mouth', mippi) of the LORD from human thought and way. Genesis 1's 'to create' (bara', H1254) has only God as grammatical subject. Hebrews 11:3 attributes world-framing to 'the word of God' (rhemati theou). Outcome-effecting speech is grammatically restricted to the divine first person across the canon. Asking-promises (Matthew 7:7-8, John 14:13-14, John 15:7, Mark 11:24, James 1:5-6) are petitions to God, scoped by 1 John 5:14's 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou), and qualified by the suffering data (2 Corinthians 12:7-9 hapax (a word that occurs only once) 'thorn' (skolops), Paul's denied request; 1 Timothy 5:23 Timothy's stomach; Philippians 2:27 Epaphroditus ill; 2 Timothy 4:20 Trophimus left sick) where the asking pattern does not produce the asked outcome.

word_of_faith_positive_confession: denies the proposition · This lens reads the asking-promise cluster as a class of unconditional guarantees keyed by spoken faith. Strongest texts: Mark 11:23, 'whoever may say' (hos an eipe) with 'believe' (pisteue) yielding 'it will be to him' (estai auto); Matthew 7:7-8, 'ask and it will be given' (aiteite kai dothesetai) with the universal 'everyone asking receives' (pas ho aiton lambanei); John 14:13-14, 'whatever you ask I will do' (ho ti an aitesete poieso); John 15:7, 'whatever you wish ask and it will be done' (ho ean thelete aitesasthe kai genesetai); Proverbs 18:21, 'death and life are in the power of the tongue' (mavet vechayim beyad lashon); the Genesis 1 'and he said' (vayomer) pattern read as a transferable principle. The strongest form of the lens treats spoken faith as the activating mechanism the Father has bound himself to. Its lexical weakness is that 1 John 5:14 explicitly attaches 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou) to the asking-promise, and the canon supplies the suffering data where the same pattern fails.

kingdom_now_dominion: partially affirms the lens, denies the proposition's converse · Reads Genesis 1:26, 'have dominion' (radah), plus Psalm 8 and Romans 5:17, 'reign in life', as restoring a creative speech function to believers. Lexically 'have dominion' (radah, H7287) governs over fish, fowl, beasts, never over reality-by-decree, and 'to reign' (basileuo) in Romans 5:17 is 'in life' (en zoe), not 'in word' (en logo). The lens has biblical content about delegated rule but does not lexically reach the claim that human utterance carries creative force.

The verdict rests on grammatical analysis of who speaks the efficacious word (divine first-person suffixes and 'from my mouth' (mippi) in Isaiah; 'to create' (bara') with God as subject in Genesis 1; 'the word of God' (rhemati theou) in Hebrews 11:3) and on the conditional ('if-then' clause) structure of the asking-promises ('if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese) in James 4:15; 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou) in 1 John 5:14; abiding-in-Christ in John 15:7; 'in my name' (en to onomati mou) bounded by 'so that the Father may be glorified' (hina doxasthe ho pater) in John 14:13). The suffering data (2 Corinthians 12 hapax (a word that occurs only once) 'thorn' (skolops), Timothy, Epaphroditus, Trophimus) operates as the canonical control on any reading of the asking-promises as unconditional speaker-controlled guarantees.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does human speech possess intrinsic creative force such that decreeing or declaring causes God to bring about the speaker's stated outcome, and is the Creator's word the same kind of thing as the creature's word or categorically distinct?

The stem is framed as a denial (human speech does not possess intrinsic creative force; the words are categorically distinct), which preloads a verdict against positive-confession theology. The neutralized form poses it as an open question about the locus of efficacious speech and the relation of divine and human word. The verdict is still derived on the original stem from the lexical data, which independently locates outcome-binding force in the divine word (Isaiah 55:11, 'my word' (devari) 'from my mouth' (mippi); Genesis 1, 'to create' (bara') with God as subject; Hebrews 11:3, 'the word of God' (rhemati theou)) and scopes the asking-promises by an explicit divine-will conditional ('if-then' clause) (1 John 5:14, 'according to his will' (kata to thelema autou); James 4:15, 'if the Lord wills' (ean ho kyrios thelese)).

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Isa.55.11
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.1.1
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1697
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H2654
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H1254
morphology	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.115.3
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2309
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2307
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0154
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4647
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4200
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.4.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.5.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.12.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.11.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Ps.115.3

cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Mark.11.23
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.6.5
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interlinear	BibleHub-interlinear	fair-use-policy	no	John.10.34

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Flags

ecm-shadow